

LESSON 11: Authority Files

11.0 Authority files or Controlled Vocabularies

- Authority files contain names and subjects that can be added to catalogue records to simplify searching by providing a consistent vocabulary for access points. The specialized scope of most authority files means that libraries and archives often rely on several vocabulary sources.
- A controlled vocabulary or an authority file is a limited set of **consistently used and carefully defined words or phrases** that have been pre-selected by the designers of the controlled vocabulary, in contrast to uncontrolled vocabularies where there is no restriction on the values that can be used.
- Controlled vocabularies enable librarians to provide uniform access to materials in library catalogues and to provide clear identification of authors and subject headings. **For example, works about ‘movies’, ‘motion pictures’, ‘cinema’, and ‘films’ are all entered under the established subject heading ‘motion pictures’ (Library of Congress Authorities, 2008).**
- Conducting a search in a database that uses controlled vocabularies or indexing terms is more efficient and precise. Once a correct term is found, most of the relevant items are returned for a single search, meaning that there is no need to search for all the other synonyms for that term.
- Without basic terminology control, inconsistent or incorrect metadata can profoundly degrade the quality of search results. **For example, without a controlled vocabulary, ‘candy’ and ‘sweet’ might be used to refer to the same concept.**
- Controlled vocabularies may also reduce the likelihood of spelling errors when recording metadata

11.1 Authority control maintenance

Authority control is maintained by means of authority files (discussed above) which record the correct form of headings (for example, personal name headings). **The point of authority control is that if catalogues are to help users identify information resources, there needs to be consistency, particularly in the case of popular**

access points such as author, title and subject description. If cataloguers are to provide an effective service, they must ensure, for example, that if users search for resources by a particular, known author, the system will retrieve all records relating to the author's work and not just some of them. **Authority files, therefore, have a function similar to thesauri. A thesaurus is in fact a form of authority file which provides a list of preferred and non-preferred subject terms, with linkages between preferred and non-preferred terms, between broader and narrower terms and between related terms.** Where authority files differ from thesauri is that they are a guide to preferred and non-preferred vocabulary for a range of fields, whereas thesauri specifically control vocabulary in subject fields. National libraries are often a source of authority files: for example, personal name and corporate name file listings.

Authority files may function in much the same way as thesauri, that is, as listings to which cataloguers refer, but in library management systems, they may be more than this. Certain types of data, such as authors' names, may be stored only once in a system, in an authority file separate from the main bibliographic file. In fact, some data elements in the bibliographic file, for example, personal names, corporate names, titles, series titles and subject headings may be drawn from discrete authority files in order to construct and present a bibliographic record. **Each authority file (for example, author authority file) would in that case list preferred terms, along with relations (for example, non-preferred terms) and pointers to those bibliographic records which 'contain' the terms.** The pointers are often system-generated bibliographic record numbers which appear in both files. As well as using authority files for access elements, such as author and title, the cataloguing system may also maintain an authority file for other data elements, such as publishers' names.

Features of authority control include:

- Automatic creation of an authority file entry when a new heading is created or imported with a new catalogue record
- Automatic deletion of references when the last catalogue record with which they are linked is deleted

- Ability to import authority file terms from an external source, for example, the integration of Library of Congress Subject Headings with local systems.
- Ability to establish a reference structure among authority file headings
- Global change facility, so that, for example, when country's name changes all instances in the subject authority file of the old name can be changed to the new one, with an appropriate reference from the disused name
- Ability to merge authority file headings, for example, where two entries in the author authority file are for the same author
- Easy navigation between cataloguing procedures and authority files
- Listing of new and dropped authority file terms, for cataloguers to review

The ease with which cataloguers can move between catalogue creation and authority files has not always been satisfactory, but the use of windows presents cataloguers with the opportunity to check authority files while in the middle of entering catalogue data. Many software packages now allow the operator to split the screen into a number of boxed areas or windows and run more than one application simultaneously (or at least display more than one application and run one of them). For the cataloguer this means being able to access authority files while creating records, instead of having to leave the record creation application. A similar facility should be available if the cataloguer is editing records.